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Changing demography:
The proportion of aged people in
the population is rising steadily

SUMEET INDER SINGH

The state should **PENALISE** those children who do not care for their elderly parents and reward those who do

The demographic landscape of India has seen unprecedented changes over the past 50 years. A rapid and spectacular transition from high to relatively low mortality and fertility is not only slowing population growth but also fundamentally changing the age composition of India's population. The proportion of population aged 60 and above is rising and is projected to rise significantly in the next 50 years. The proportion of the aged was only 5.6 per cent of the total population in 1950. It rose to 7.6 per cent in 2000 but is projected to rise to around 20.6 per cent by 2050. A demographic time bomb or an "agequake" may come as a tremor for the Indian economy and society with devastating consequences.

A political age quake has already occurred

in the last parliamentary elections, missing the attention of many pundits. The aged constitute around 13 per cent of the electorate in India. In a country where the elders, to a great extent, depend on interest earnings, it is almost certain that a great chunk of senior citizens voted against the BJP government's interest rate reform policy. The proportion of seniors in the electorate is rising: the number will hit 27 per cent in 2050. With rising levels of literacy and along with it, the growing realisation of the importance of the three core values of life—life sustenance, freedom and self-esteem—elder disenchantment of public policies will be matters of great political interest.

However, as the aged are not sufficiently organised as in developed countries, they receive little from the budgetary share. This despite the labour force participation rate of the

Slow to React

DESPITE SIGNING THE INTERNATIONAL PLAN OF ACTION ON AGEING IN 1982 IN VIENNA, THE NATIONAL POLICY ON OLDER PERSONS WAS ANNOUNCED ONLY IN 1999.